Dispiriting data from medical studies show the extent of the harm. In May, the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) launched a national study to define baseline health parameters for Indian children and adolescents—a sign that chronic disease in the young is no longer being treated as a niche concern. According to the *Indian Journal of Community Medicine* (2025), overweight prevalence among Indian schoolchildren now ranges between 10 per cent and 30 per cent in several urban areas. A 2023 meta-analysis in the journal *Clinical Epidemiology and Global Health* estimated childhood obesity prevalence at 8.4 per cent nationally, with higher rates in cities. Studies in the *Journal of Clinical and Experimental Hepatology* (2022) and *International Journal of Medical and Pharmaceutical Research* (2025) suggest NAFLD is present in 3–10 per cent of children and rising sharply. Asthma prevalence among children was estimated at 7.9 per cent in a 2022 study published in *Lung India*.

THE INDOOR CHILD

At the root of many sicknesses, say experts, is limited exposure to the rough-and-tumble of playgrounds. Childhoods are now spent in air-conditioned rooms, much of it spent while poring over small screens.

Research increasingly suggests that these shifts matter biologically. A 2026 study in the *International Journal of Medical and Pharmaceutical Research* linked excessive screen exposure with sleep disturbances in urban schoolchildren. Screen dependence fills the vacuum left behind by shrinking outdoor life. "From obesity and constipation to behavioural problems, we see multiple health issues linked to excessive screen exposure," says Dr Deepak Ugra, senior consultant paediatrics at Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai.

However, doctors say the larger issue goes beyond screens. "The body is not designed to be kept away from the outside world—it is designed to be in active, ongoing conversation with it," says Dr Shreya Dubey, consultant child specialist, obstetrics & gynaecology, CK Birla Hospital, Gurugram. She points to evidence linking reduced microbial exposure in childhood with rising allergies and inflammatory disorders in urban populations.



SLEEP DISORDERS

A 2025 study found 40 per cent of preschoolers in Chennai had sleep disturbances linked to screen use

SYMPTOMS: Irritability, fatigue, poor focus

CAUSE: Late-night screens and overscheduled routines

TREATMENT: Behavioural sleep therapy, treatment for enlarged tonsils/adenoids, management of anxiety

CURE: Fixed sleep schedules, reduced screen time

STRESS-LINKED SYMPTOMS

Rising cases of stress-linked headaches, stomach aches in urban children

SYMPTOMS: Anxiety, headaches, stomach pain, fatigue

CAUSE: Academic pressure, lack of wind-down time

TREATMENT: Cognitive behavioural therapy, specialised programmes that address anxiety

CURE: Emotional support, slower schedules, outdoor activities

METABOLIC DYSFUNCTION

Metabolic syndrome markers are appearing in Indian children aged 11–13

SYMPTOMS: High blood sugar, fatigue, obesity, insulin resistance

CAUSE: Processed diets, inactivity, chronic poor sleep

TREATMENT: Glucose monitors, insulin therapy, Metformin, tracking blood sugar

CURE: Early monitoring & treatment, healthy diet, physical activity

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE